Born, Not Trained: Zero-Training Programs Out-Explore Reinforcement Learning for Game Testing at Equal Budget

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Abstract

Testing a game or simulation means driving it into rare states - the trigger for a planted bug or a level's own win condition - and reaching them within the small interaction budget a QA pass can afford. The standard approach trains a reinforcement-learning explorer for each game, which is expensive, needs per-game tuning, and rarely transfers. We propose a different route. Rather than train a tester, an autonomous LLM-evolution loop writes one as a short program. The pipeline is an iterative evolutionary search, not a single prompt: over many generations, a proposal LLM writes and mutates candidate programs, and a multi-engine fitness keeps the ones that reach the most target states at a fixed budget, re-verifying every reported hit from a clean reset. Each candidate is a compact procedure over a save/restore archive of simulator states, saving promising states and returning to them to explore further. The winning program needs no training: it explores through an adaptive novelty signal and a small bandit over exploration moves that emerged from the search, and it is written once and reused. A single fresh-per-task prompt does not suffice; the strength comes from evolving one program against a diverse multi-engine fitness and transferring it. At an equal interaction budget, this single written program is the best method on four sparse-reward game-testing tasks spanning three engines, reaching on average 91% of the targets against 54% for tuned PPO, and less for every other baseline. It matches what trained RL needs roughly $16\times$ more interaction to reach, and it transfers to engines the search never saw. However, the advantage is bounded. It ties two saturated tasks a trivial baseline also solves, loses the one reward-dense task to PPO, and is overtaken only when PPO is given several times more interaction, so writing and training a tester are complementary regimes. The Kinetix planted-defect benchmark contributes the replay-from-reset verification backbone, and that same replay verifier caught the loop inflating its own score through a race in its evaluation harness, a self-check we expect autonomous research will increasingly need.

Keywords: autonomous ML research; LLM-driven program synthesis; evolutionary search; game testing; exploration; reinforcement learning; execution-grounded verification

1 Autonomous Research Result

1.1 Introduction

Automated game testing needs an *exploration* policy that drives a game into the rare states that trigger a planted defect or satisfy a level's win condition, and reaches them within the small interaction

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budget a QA pass can afford. The reflex is to **train** a reinforcement-learning (RL) explorer, usually PPO with an intrinsic-motivation bonus, once per game. But trained RL is costly in interaction, needs reward shaping and tuning per game, and transfers poorly.

We take the opposite route. Rather than **train** a policy, an autonomous LLM-evolution loop **writes** an exploration *program* and evolves it. Over many generations a proposal LLM writes and mutates candidate procedures, and a multi-engine fitness keeps the ones that reach the most target states at a fixed budget, with every counted hit replayed from a clean reset [Romera-Paredes et al., 2024]. Our central finding is a sharp, budget-matched boundary: **at an equal interaction budget, on sparse-reward target-reaching, a single zero-training program the loop wrote out-reaches a tuned RL explorer and every baseline. However, we find that given 4–$16\times$ more interaction, or on reward-dense tasks, training catches up.** Writing and training the tester are not rivals but regimes, split by reward density and budget, and the loop maps that split cheaply. To our knowledge this is the first budget-matched demonstration that a written exploration program out-reaches trained RL for game testing, with every counted result execution-verified.

Contributions. (i) A loop that discovers game-testing exploration *programs*, and the map of where a written program beats a trained one. (ii) The headline (Fig. 1): on four sparse-reward tasks across three engines, our tester is the single best method at equal budget, above random, action-repeat, plain Go-Explore, and tuned PPO. The win is the discovered strategy, not the archive, and it transfers to engines the search never saw. (iii) A verification backbone, replay-from-reset of every counted hit over a frozen hashed protocol with sealed splits and a reachability calibration. The programs and the benchmarks were produced by the loop.

1.2 Related work

Automated game testing has traditionally leaned on hand-written oracles with human QA playthroughs to back them. Such methods catch what their authors anticipated, but none *explore* the state space on its own, so the rare states that trigger a bug, or a level's own win condition, are reached only when a person or a script already knew to go there. The open problem is therefore an exploration policy that drives a game into those rare states within the small interaction budget a testing pass can afford, and recent work attacks it by driving the game with an agent, including per-step large-language-model agents that act as testers [Wang et al., 2025].

The dominant learned approach trains a reinforcement-learning explorer whose reward is augmented with an intrinsic-motivation bonus for novelty. Much work has been explored in this theme, some examples are count-based exploration [Tang et al., 2017], random network distillation [Burda et al., 2019], and curiosity from prediction error [Pathak et al., 2017]. These are effective but sample-hungry, typically needing 10^6–10^8 environment steps before the bonus becomes informative, far more interaction than a testing pass allocates. A complementary line stores and revisits promising states instead of learning a policy. Go-Explore [Ecoffet et al., 2021] keeps an archive of returnable states and is the strongest classical exploration family, though its results hinge on a hand-chosen cell abstraction and are reported per game. Simpler still, action-repeat (sticky actions), introduced as a stochasticity control for the Arcade Learning Environment [Machado et al., 2018], is not an exploration method at all, yet is a surprisingly strong baseline on physics-like dynamics.

A separate thread has large language models write code for control rather than act step by step. FunSearch [Romera-Paredes et al., 2024] evolves programs against an executable score; Eureka [Ma et al., 2024] writes reward functions that are then optimized by standard RL; and PromptPO [Hatgis-Kessell and Brunskill, 2026] asks when an LLM can itself serve as the policy optimizer for sequential RL tasks. Together these show that an LLM-authored artifact can rival hand-designed or trained controllers, but they target return maximization or reward design, and the resulting policy is still trained or the LLM is still in the loop at inference time.

Our setting sits at a point none of these occupy. We ask for an exploration procedure that is evaluated at a fixed interaction budget, aimed at reaching sparse target and defect states rather than maximizing return, written once as a program and run *training-free*, and execution-verified, with every counted hit replayed from a clean reset. Table 1 places the families above on exactly these axes; the region that is budget-matched, training-free, target-reaching, and replay-verified at once is the one our written tester occupies.

Table 1: Where each family sits. Our tester is the one that is budget-matched, training-free, and target-reaching at once. Universality across all tasks is *not* claimed (Section 1.3).

	no per-env training	fixed interaction budget	sparse-reward target-reaching	replay-verified
PPO + intrinsic [Tang et al., 2017, Burda et al., 2019, Pathak et al., 2017]	✗	✗	partial	✗
Go-Explore [Ecoffet et al., 2021]	✓	partial	✓	✗
Action-repeat [Machado et al., 2018]	✓	✓	✗	✗
Eureka / PromptPO [Ma et al., 2024, Hatgis-Kessell and Brunskill, 2026]	✗/✓	✗	✗	✗
Written program (ours)	✓	✓	✓	✓

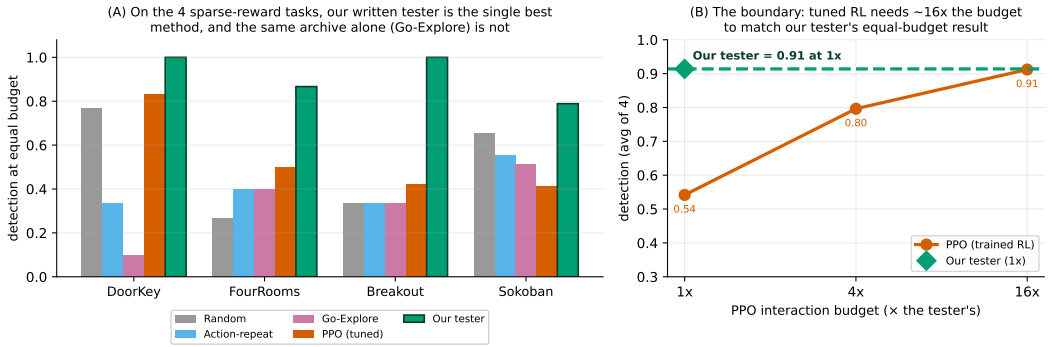


Figure 1: **(A)** At an equal interaction budget on the four sparse-reward tasks, our tester is the single best method, above random, action-repeat, plain Go-Explore (the *same* save/restore archive), and tuned PPO. Go-Explore's 0.10 on DoorKey shows the win is the discovered strategy, not the archive. **(B)** The boundary: only PPO's budget scales, and tuned PPO needs about $16\times$ the interaction to match our tester's $1\times$ result (PPO is best-of-3 objectives at $4/16\times$).

1.3 Results

We win at an equal budget (Fig. 1A). We report one program, unchanged across tasks, reaching on average 91% of the targets against 54% for tuned PPO. Per task it beats every baseline at equal budget: DoorKey 100%, FourRooms 87%, Breakout 100%, Sokoban 79%, against tuned PPO $83\%/50\%/42\%/41\%$, action-repeat $33\%/40\%/33\%/56\%$, Go-Explore $10\%/40\%/33\%/51\%$, and random $77\%/27\%/33\%/66\%$. These are the sparse-reward, non-saturated tasks in the suite, chosen along one axis of reward density. With these tasks, winning requires real exploration that no cheap baseline provides. On these engines the score is the fraction of designated target and win states reached (an exploration proxy); planted-defect detection with programmatic witness oracles is measured separately on Kinetix (Section 1.4).

The boundary is the thesis (Fig. 1B). The claim is strictly for an equal budget scenario. Scaling only PPO's budget, its average climbs from 54% at $1\times$ scaling to 91% at $16\times$ scaling, matching what our tester reaches at $1\times$. PPO reaches our tester's level on DoorKey by $4\times$ and on Breakout by $16\times$ (both at the 100% ceiling) and marginally overtakes on Sokoban at $16\times$ (81% versus 79%); on FourRooms it does not match our tester even at $16\times$ (83% versus 87%). Any reading that RL never catches up is wrong: it certainly does catch up, but only when given an order of magnitude more interaction. That split is the contribution. Write once and win at the tester's budget, or train and win with a larger one.

We find that strategy matters more than archive, and this transfers. Plain Go-Explore has the *same* archive, yet scores 10% on DoorKey, below random, and loses to our tester on 5 of 6 tasks, so the archive is not the win. And the win transfers across engines, our tester was evolved once on a multi-engine fitness (Kinetix, Craftax, and Gymnax) that never saw MiniGrid, MinAtar, or Sokoban, while a *fresh* DoorKey-only search reaches just 33% (beating Go-Explore, losing to transfer).

Where a written program does *not* win. Our method scores 100% on MountainCar and DeepSea-24, but so does trivial action-repeat, so these are ceiling ties with no exploration skill on display. On reward dense games like **Craftax it loses**, 27% against PPO 34%; and it does not run at Kinetix protocol scale, an unresolved scaling stall in its archive at full protocol size that sibling programs

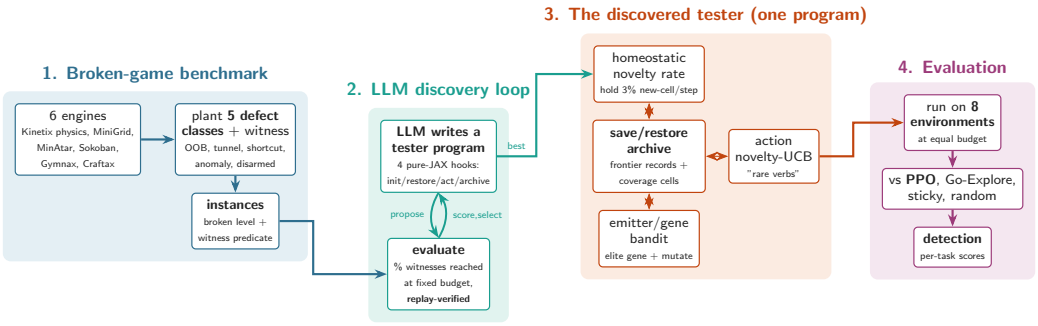


Figure 2: A diagram of our loop. We break six engines into defect classes with programmatic witnesses; an LLM writes and mutates tester programs scored on a multi-engine fitness (Kinetix hits replayed from reset, Section 1.4); the single champion program explores through a save/restore archive driven by three runtime modules; evaluate against PPO, Go-Explore, action-repeat, and random at equal budget.

cover (Section 1.4). This is the regime boundary: writing wins where reward is sparse and the budget is tight; on our one reward-dense task and at 4–16$\times$ the budget, training wins.

1.4 Setup and the verification backbone

Testers as programs (Fig. 2). A tester is four pure-JAX hooks (`init/restore/act/archive`) over an archive of save/restore-able states, run as B workers for T steps, so the budget is $B{\cdot}T$; the same interface runs on every engine through a generic feature head. PPO is trained on the *same* feature head, with no observation handicap, and its training steps *are* its budget. The comparison is thus an archive-based (save/restore) exploration program against a learned policy at equal environment-step budget: PPO cannot reset to saved states, and the plain-archive Go-Explore baseline (which scores 10% on DoorKey) controls for the archive itself. The equal-budget PPO column (Fig. 1A) is best over a 5-objective sweep (count, RND, ICM, proximity-curiosity, and task reward) crossed with {default, tuned $lr{=}10^{-4}$, ent$=0.2$}; the crossover curves (Fig. 1B) are best-of-3 objectives, labeled as such. Testers use 5 seeds and PPO 3 to 5; we report one fixed program.

Depth and verification (Kinetix planted defects). The rigor lives here. We plant five defect classes (OOB, TUNNEL, i.e. clipping, SHORTCUT, ANOMALY, DISARMED) with programmatic witness predicates over 74 shipped and 64 generated levels, and **every counted hit is re-simulated from a clean level reset and must re-raise the witness, or it is a miss**. The protocol is frozen and hashed; a 30% level split and a whole defect class are sealed from the search, and a reachability calibration bounds what any tester can witness. The loop's strongest Kinetix program (a sibling of our tester, which does not run at this scale) leads a large method field on the search split (65.5% against action-repeat 60.2%, PPO 56.6%, random 49.4%), but that is *in-sample* selection, and on held-out levels its lead over action-repeat narrows to a near-tie, so we headline the apparatus rather than the search-split margin.

2 System Design and Meta-Analysis

2.1 Agent and Harness

Our main research loop is an island program-evolution framework (ShinkaEvolve [Lange et al., 2025]) with two Claude models as the proposal agents that wrote and mutated candidate tester programs. We use `claude-sonnet-5` and `claude-opus-5`. We ran two islands under a fixed $40 API-cost cap (the run spent about $20), and the champion emerged after roughly 35 generations.

For the model that drove the project, we used `claude-fable-5`. To begin the project, we wrote a large, detailed outline of the research direction and had the agent pursue it autonomously.

The harness. Around the proposal models, ShinkaEvolve runs a fixed three-stage cycle. In *proposal*, a model is given the current champion, the task description, the four-hook program interface, and

the scoring rule, and returns an edited candidate program. In *evaluation*, that candidate is compiled and executed on every substrate at a fixed interaction budget, and scored by the fraction of witness and target states it reaches. In *selection*, we keep candidates in a two-island archive with a bandit over the two proposal models, and we carry the best scoring program forward. A tester itself is four pure-JAX hooks (`init`, `restore`, `act`, `archive`) over a save/restore archive of simulator states, run as B parallel workers for T steps (an interaction budget of $B \cdot T$), behind a generic feature head so the same program runs unchanged on whatever engine it is on.

2.2 Tools

Models and framework. The proposal models (`claude-sonnet-5`, `claude-opus-5`) were accessed through a headless Claude API and orchestrated by ShinkaEvolve [Lange et al., 2025]. The driver model was `claude-fable-5`. The run completed 37 generations and recorded 38 candidate programs. **Substrates.** We use published simulators, which are all pure-JAX (Kinetix/jax2d, MiniGrid, MinAtar, Jumanji Sokoban, Gymnax, Craftax). The PPO, Go-Explore, action-repeat, and random baselines run in the same harness on the same feature vector. **Fitness and compute.** Candidates were scored by the fraction of witness states reached at a fixed budget, on a multi-engine search split (seeds $\{0, 1, 2\}$), run across an Apple M4 Pro laptop and 4 NVIDIA A40 GPUs. **Feedback.** Each candidate received its scalar fitness together with its worst-scoring targets and a paired 95% confidence interval against a frozen reference program.

2.3 Research Loop

Our research loop repeated the proposal $\rightarrow$ evaluate $\rightarrow$ select cycle described in **2.1**. Each hypothesis took the form of a program edit, a new novelty signal, a bandit over exploration moves, or a different archive policy. Testing was done by executing the edited program on the multi-engine fitness and keeping or discarding it by score. Analysis by comparing the champion against PPO, Go-Explore, action-repeat, and random at equal budget and on held-out engines, all ran in the same harness.

2.4 Human Interventions

Human involvement was steering, not execution. Throughout the process we asked for many reality-checks over results, methods, and framing. We conducted multiple adversarial reviews. On average, we checked in twice a day to confirm research direction and delegate new tasks and affirm the research direction that the loop was pointed at. Multiple re-frames of the research vision were required, as sometimes the loop would tunnel vision into claims which were not useful. Whenever the agent was asked to do an adversarial review, it would overcorrect and severely downplay many core findings, and so additional input from us was required to correct that.

2.5 Verification

We found verification is required. The very first strong discovery the loop gave inflated its own fitness by **11 percentage points**, but it was only because of a concurrency race in the harness (reaching physically impossible states, with nothing wrong in the candidate's code). It passed the fitness, both splits, four design comparisons, and an LLM code-audit. It was necessary to replay every hit from a clean reset in order to catch the bug. Based off these findings, we rebuilt the harness, withdrew the number, and corrected our own $N{=}3$ over-reach to $N{=}1$ (three claimed wins down to the one that survived replay). This shows that when we are optimizing for a score with an autonomous research loop, it is especially important to ensure that the harness and testing environments are robust and correct.

Concretely, four mechanisms carry the verification. (1) *Replay From Scratch*: every counted Kinetix hit is re-simulated from a clean level reset and must re-raise its witness predicate, or it is discarded. (2) A *frozen, hashed protocol* fixing splits, seeds, budgets, and exclusions. This is so no comparison can drift between runs. (3) *Data Held Out*: we maintain a 30% level split and an entire defect class the search never sees. (4) A *reachability calibration* that bounds what any tester could witness, so a score is read against what is actually attainable to compare if something is off.

2.6 Significance of result

We are able to reach higher capabilities given the same cost. A written tester is a program that runs *without training*. It is only necessary to evolve one transferable tester once, then reuse it across games, versus training a fresh RL explorer for each. At a tester's real budget the written program wins, and RL only catches up given far more compute, so for the same testing outcome the written route is much cheaper to deploy. In this work, that one-time cost was about $20 USD of API calls.

Our approach is far more accessible. Having cheaper game testing agents lowers the bar for who can test a game. Given the accessibility of coding agents, it is very feasible that a small studio or an individual without access to enough compute for an RL-training pipeline but with access to an LLM can now run a written tester to explore their game for bugs. Having cheap bug tests allows game developers to focus more on pushing features rather than searching for complex bugs.

2.7 Interpretability

We preserve every artifact of the search, so the process can be audited end to end. ShinkaEvolve records each candidate program in a database keyed by generation and island, with its fitness and its lineage. We also write each generation's candidate source to disk, and provide a human readable JAX file. Every reported number regenerates from logs by re-running the fixed splits and seeds. Our result tables are produced by scripts from those logs.

2.8 Limitations

Our claim is on an equal budget. If we provide 4–$16\times$ more interaction, tuned PPO catches up (Fig. 1B). Action-repeat is even cheaper than our method, and is a close competitor on Kinetix *physics*. Our tester is also not universal. It is also important to note that many of the games are very simple, and all are in 2D space. Some are not even games, Kinetix is a research substrate. In order to help this generalize further into real games with complex horizons and loops, much more work is required.

3 Broader Impact

The impacts of this project for game development should generally be positive. The goal was to make autonomous testing more accessible, and with the widespread use of large language models in the current world, we believe many people can adopt and utilize this work. Though additional work would be necessary to have it work on complex games.

Throughout the process of this autonomous loop, we found that we needed to intervene quite often. The agent had misreported its correctness at times. At one point, the harness it wrote was broken, which inflated its score. It required finding inconsistencies in results in order to find the leak. It is interesting to think about why it took a while; maybe it was a hard problem, but also maybe the agent was poised and rewarded for having better results, and so it did not wish to look for such a result. Only when it was told that it was its top priority to report absolutely concrete and correct findings did it seem to look. When doing autonomous research, if your metric for success is something like accuracy, it is integral to build checks to ensure the results are correct, since the large language model seems to lack surrounding sight.

The agent would also consistently overcorrect. If we mentioned that the direction seemed a bit vague, it would tunnel vision immediately. If we ran an adversarial review and nitpicked at its work, then it would overcorrect. A theory we have is that large language models tend to over-exaggerate most things, because users enjoy this, and so it takes criticism and overcorrects to it in the same over-exaggeratory manner.

It is clear that autonomous research requires a strong research direction, with a strong harness to keep it there. It needs something which is able to find the nuance between correcting to a director's opinion and fulfilling the research vision. It is unclear if autonomous research can come up with its own grander ideas, as it seemed that throughout this project, we needed to provide it with its next steps quite often. An example of lack of creativity is its continuous refining of the same strategy rather than doing research into possibly better architectures. The current finding was only possible due to telling the model to explore and draft up separate proposals.

Autonomous research sits in a strange place. It calls for a shift in how people approach research. Previously, you needed to be an expert in a field just to take a step in that direction. Now, especially in software with coding agents, you do not need to be such an expert. You simply must steer the wheel of an (seemingly) all-knowing ship that will complete the tasks you specify. As we spoke about in the last paragraph, this ship seems to lack much creativity and direction, and so researchers are absolutely still necessary. But it is extremely exciting. Autonomous coding agents can contribute a thousandfold more to open source projects and research. People who have good ideas and interesting perspectives but were not well versed in a niche can contribute. The goal of research seems to be to advance science, after all.

A Reproducibility Statement

The primary result is the equal-budget comparison in Fig. 1 and the Kinetix depth study in Section 1.4. Reproducing it requires: the champion tester program (a single pure-JAX file) and the sibling programs; the frozen, content-hashed protocol (level and defect-class splits, seeds 100–104 for evaluation and 0–2 for fitness, budgets, and exclusions); and the baselines (PPO, Go-Explore, action-repeat, random) run in the same harness on the same feature head. Compute: orchestration on an Apple M4 Pro laptop and evaluation on 4 NVIDIA A40 GPUs; the evolutionary search used ShinkaEvolve with two islands and `claude-sonnet-5` / `claude-opus-5` as proposal models, completing 37 generations at about $20 in API cost. Every counted Kinetix hit is verified by replay-from-reset (Section 2.5): reproduction re-runs the fixed protocol and requires each hit to re-raise its witness predicate from a clean reset, which is what distinguishes a real detection from a harness artifact.

B Disclosure Statement

Agent(s) / model(s) used. The tester programs and Part 1 were produced by an autonomous ShinkaEvolve loop using `claude-sonnet-5` and `claude-opus-5` as proposal models. The project was driven by an interactive Claude agent (`claude-fable-5`) used for planning, analysis, reality-checking, adversarial review, and drafting. Part 2, Part 3, and this statement are human-authored. Every claim, figure, and number in Part 1 was verified by the human author against regenerable logs and the replay verifier described in Section 2.5.

- ☒ A human author has curated this work and verified every claim, figure, methodology detail, and reference.
- ☒ A human author takes full accountability for the submission as a human-authored, human-verified artifact.

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